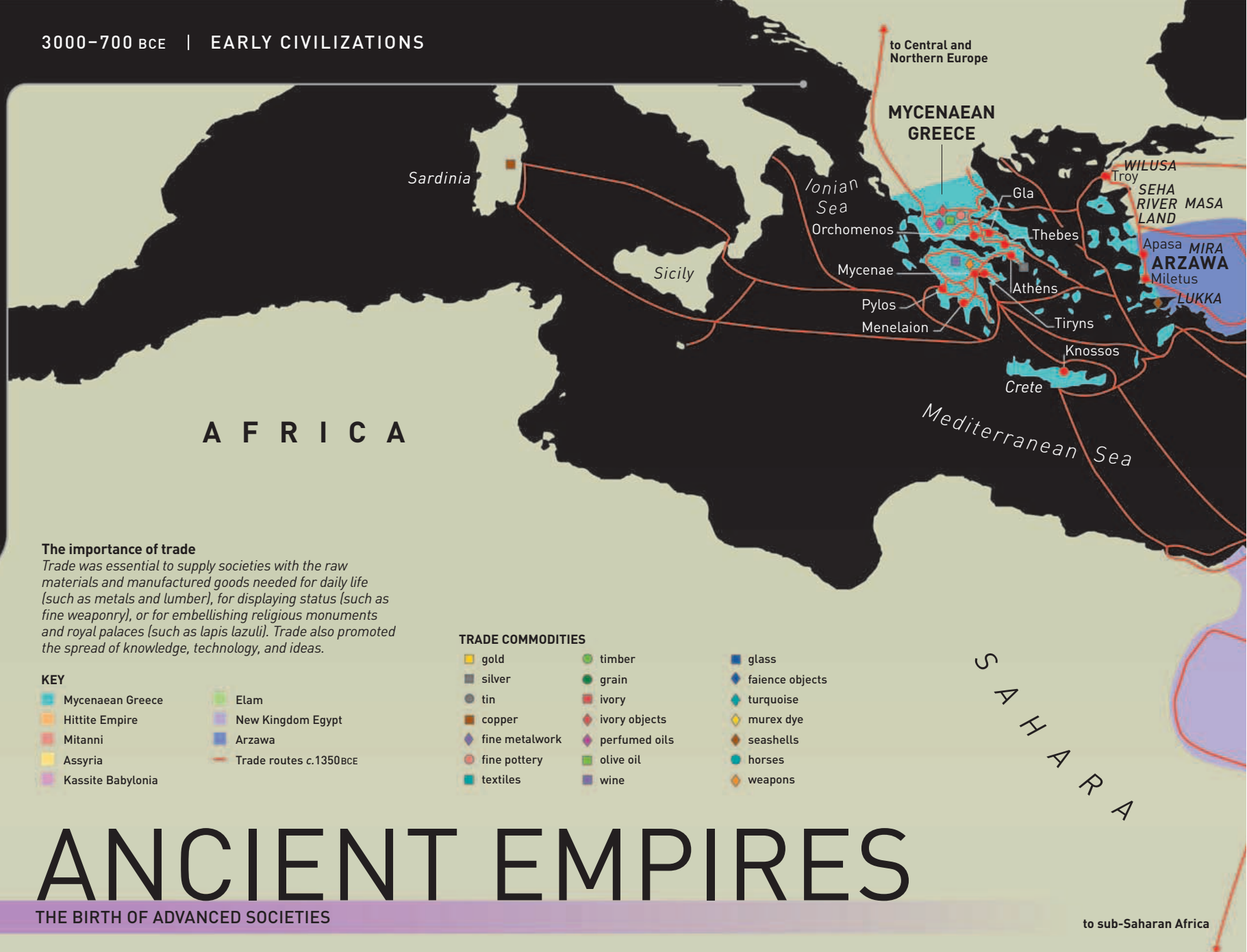




The importance of trade

Trade was essential to supply societies with the raw materials and manufactured goods needed for daily life (such as metals and lumber), for displaying status (such as fine weaponry), or for embellishing religious monuments and royal palaces (such as lapis lazuli). Trade also promoted the spread of knowledge, technology, and ideas.

KEY

Mycenaean Greece	Elam
Hittite Empire	New Kingdom Egypt
Mitanni	Arzawa
Assyria	Trade routes c.1350BCE
Kassite Babylonia	

TRADE COMMODITIES

gold	timber	glass
silver	grain	faience objects
tin	ivory	turquoise
copper	ivory objects	murex dye
fine metalwork	perfumed oils	seashells
fine pottery	olive oil	horses
textiles	wine	weapons

ANCIENT EMPIRES

THE BIRTH OF ADVANCED SOCIETIES

In the 3rd millennium BCE, states emerged in Egypt, Mesopotamia, and the Indus. Urban society was consolidated in Western Asia in the 2nd millennium, and powerful states vied for control of lands; in contrast, in South Asia, towns disappeared. Complex societies emerged in China and the Americas.

The exceptional agricultural productivity of the Nile, Euphrates, Indus (see p.26), and Yellow (see p.31) river valleys undoubtedly played a part in the precocious emergence of civilizations in these regions. So did international trade, which was also important in the development of the first New World civilizations. Trade also enabled many neighboring societies to achieve prosperity: through time they developed complex cultures

increasingly focused on urban centers, and came into competition for resources and markets. High-level diplomacy was essential to the smooth operation of international trading networks and to success in inter-state power struggles. Royal letters found in the Egyptian capital, Akhetaten (Amarna), provide a fascinating picture of relations between the 14th-century BCE rulers of the rival great states of the eastern Mediterranean.

“FOR A LONG TIME WE HAVE HAD GOOD RELATIONS BETWEEN US KINGS...”

Babylonian king Burnaburiash II to Egyptian pharaoh Akhenaten, from the Amarna letters, 14th century BCE

THE WORLD PICTURE

Urbanism and complex societies became more widespread during the 2nd millennium BCE. While they shared many features such as trade, high agricultural productivity, dense populations, and their managerial needs, urban societies took many different forms. In the Americas, large ceremonial complexes with residential suburbs provided the focus for the communities of the wider region, strongly connected by shared religion and trade.

Advanced centers

This map shows established and emerging civilizations in the later 2nd millennium BCE. Societies of farmers and hunter-gatherers occupied other regions.

KEY

Chavín	Assyria
Olmec	Hittites
Shang	Mitanni
Mycenaeans	Elam
Egypt	
Babylonia	